

Computational Historical Research Methods

A practical framework for moving from historical sources and broad questions to a usable dataset, an analytical mode, and a specific output.

Big Takeaways

- Everything is a dataset!
- You need to transform your sources into a functional dataset. This means you need to make a database.
- Primary analytical and visualization modes:
 - Graphical
 - Spatial
- Be wary of making a digital interface (for example, a StoryMap) or website your end goal.

Steps

1. Acknowledge your larger research project or question

I am studying the sacred landscape of Profitis Ilias on Patmos, from the Bronze Age to the present day, with a key focus on the Monastery of Saint John the Theologian, which is located on its summit. How does the sacred catchment (spatial influence) of Saint John the Theologian's Monastery on Patmos change depending on the historical period, and identity groups?

2. Tease out a very specific research question

Is Saint John the Theologian represented in churches, monasteries, or private chapels located off of Profitis Ilias?

3. Push back

Can computational analysis improve my ability to collect or manage the data, analyze it, or disseminate the work?

4. Operationalize your question

Dataset(s)

Excel table of churches on Patmos, with characteristics like dedication, year of construction, and related evidence.

Analytical mode

Spatial distribution.

Specific output

A map showing the distribution of churches, color coded based on their dedication.

Alternative analytical mode

Alternatively, I could have elected to create a graph showing the distribution of saint dedications per sacred space on the island. For the purposes of my argument and broader questions pertaining to landscape, the map approach is more appropriate. You need to consider what modality best addresses your question **and** the limitations of your study, including how much time you have to do it.

Copyright Dr. Natalie M. Susmann. October 5, 2026. Brandeis Design and Innovation.